



Moviestorm.com

Download machinima software, create, share and even sell machinima at www.moviestorm.co.uk.



News at Seven

News at Seven is a project that picks up RSS feeds, reads them out using an animated character, and generates videos. Check them out at newsatseven.com

Geek life

This ranged from creating skeletons for the characters, and cosmetic touches such as costume, hair and skin texture. After this, an environment had to be modelled. Then, the characters would be keyframed, which meant that actions had to be programmed in, keeping in mind realistic movement and the physics of the animated universe. Then the lighting specialists would add in sources of light to illuminate the scene. All of this was handed on a platter to animators who used game engines for animation. Machinimators now only had to control the characters, co-ordinate their movements, and record the entire sequence using any one of the various video capturing options available.

Some game engines allowed Machinimators to program the key events for multiple characters, animate the camera in whatever way they chose, and then record the sequence. Another, more popular approach was simply to connect a Machinimating clan over LAN, then play-act the storyline, while recording it. Of course, such approaches had their limitations. In game engines that did not have a spectator view, the biggest limitation was the flexibility of the movement of the camera. But machinimators had come this far with the punk philosophy of working wonders with what you have, and that gave them the impetus over such puny hurdles. The players simply moved their characters in innovative ways, say one player driving a jeep, acting as a mobile platform for the "camera", and another standing on the top of the jeep looking around and zooming in where necessary, and recording the sequence of events being played out. The community developed camera tools, specific to different engines, which allowed unprecedented control over animations.

Another major limitation was the amount of expression the game engine allowed to the characters. Some of the characters in popular Machinima engines such as the Halo series had faces that were covered by helmets, with no faces showing at all. To compensate for such a lack of expression, Machinimators focused heavily on characterisation, making sure that all the dialogues were carefully crafted, had some consistency across episodes, and grew with the number of episodes. Innovative devices of engaging the audience included adding voices to weapons, vehicles and other objects in the gameplay environment. The movement grew with MTV airing a section called "Video Mods", essentially Machinima music videos for

popular songs, and a memorable South Park episode called *Make Love not Warcraft* which had a huge Machinima section.

Rooster Teeth Production's deadpan humour series Red Vs Blue is the most famous Machinima work so far. The series used the *Halo: Combat Evolved* engine, to tell the story of two factions stuck in a desolate canyon that no one really cared about, including the Red and Blue factions fighting over it. *This Spartan Life* is another machinima worth mentioning – for combining machinima techniques with the traditional talk show format. *This Spartan Life* was hosted in the multiplayer environments of *Halo 2*, by a character called

screen, for the viewing pleasure of an attending audience.

Skeptical about how all of this matches up to something that rolls out of major animation studios? Most of the machinima community agrees that there is a lot of ground left to cover. Hardware and gaming engines will have to improve considerably before the current quality standards of animation studios can be matched. However, this does not mean that you haven't seen machinima techniques on the large screen, or broadcast over your television. *The Chronicles of Narnia*, *The Dark Knight*, *Speed Racer* and the upcoming 2012 have all used machinima techniques in their production.

In traditional animation techniques, it was difficult to visualise or create a large number of entities together, behaving in different ways, and reacting to the environment around them. When Peter Jackson was filming the *Lord of the Rings* trilogy, he wanted some kind of software that could visualise incredibly large armies at once, and make it look realistic with individual characters in the hoards behaving like unique specimens. The breakthrough came with a software known as MASSIVE (Multiple Agent Simulation System In Virtual Environment), which combined artificial intelligence and a virtual environment with programmed physics to animate a large number of thinking entities at once. The engine has since then been used for many television commercials, movies and even some architecture and design applications where simulations of large crowds are necessary – such as stadiums and public transport systems.

Since a majority of machinima is made by small, independent clans, torrents are the best way to get and distribute machinima. A great site to download good quality machinima is www.machinima.com. The Red Vs Blue series is available at redvsblue.com and on this month's *Skoar! DVD. Rooster Teeth Production's homepage, roosterteeth.com has a lot of their other works, including

Strangerhood, a Sims 2 based situational comedy machinima. *The Spartan Life* is available at www.thisspartanlife.com. The ILL clan's web site www.illclan.com hosts their movies, and hunt around on YouTube for "Video Mods" for the MTV machinima music videos. MASSIVE is available for purchase at www.massivesoftware.com, animation studios should have a look at the MASSIVE Jet version. Archive.org has both a machinima section and speedrun section, that allows you to download the videos. 



A screenshot of *Diary of a Camper*, one of the first machinima films made



MASSIVE was used to animate the many robots in *I, Robot*.

Damian Lacedaemion, who had a guest in every episode. A unique talk show where the attendees could fire at the host for asking a stupid question, but then the host could point his gun at any attendee too. The recordings were then vidcast, and received considerable acclaim. Another unique approach was by the machinimating clan known as ILL. The ILL clan played out humorous skits in front of a live audience, often interacting with them. A video stream from the server that hosted the gameplay was projected in real time on a large